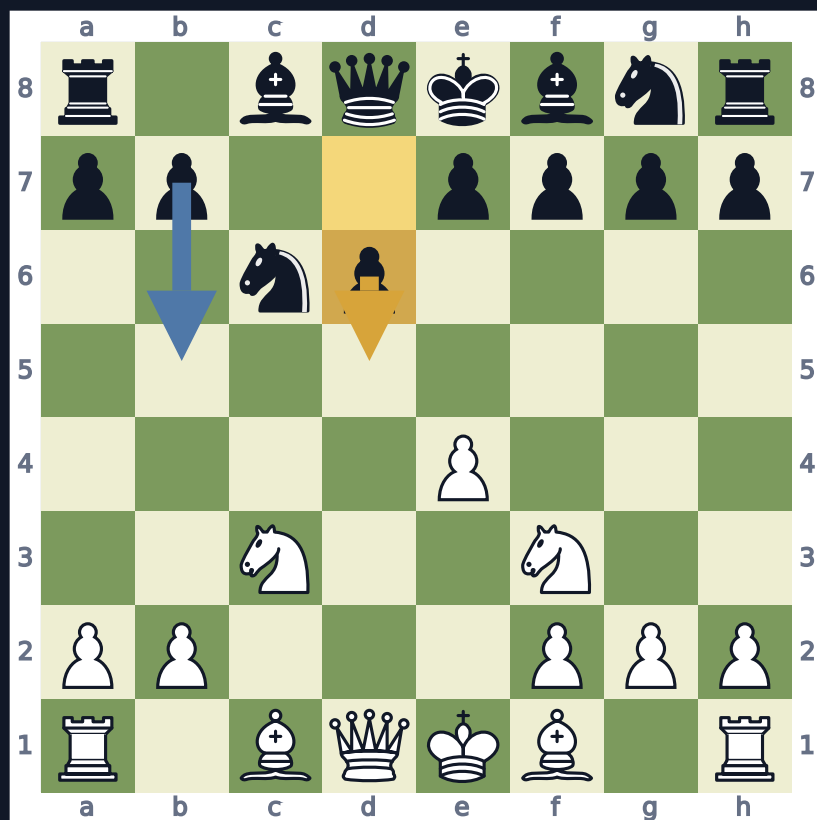


14

Smith-Morra Gambit

Accepted and declined structures, development pressure, and the rules for returning material safely.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will respect White's initiative without becoming frightened by it, using concrete development and central control.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 079 | PAGE 4

Decode: Accepting the gambit*In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.*

LESSON 080 | PAGE 8

Play: Accepting the gambit*In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.*

LESSON 081 | PAGE 12

Decode: The e5-square blockade*A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.*

LESSON 082 | PAGE 16

Play: The e5-square blockade*A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.*

LESSON 083 | PAGE 20

Decode: Declining into an Alapin*Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.*

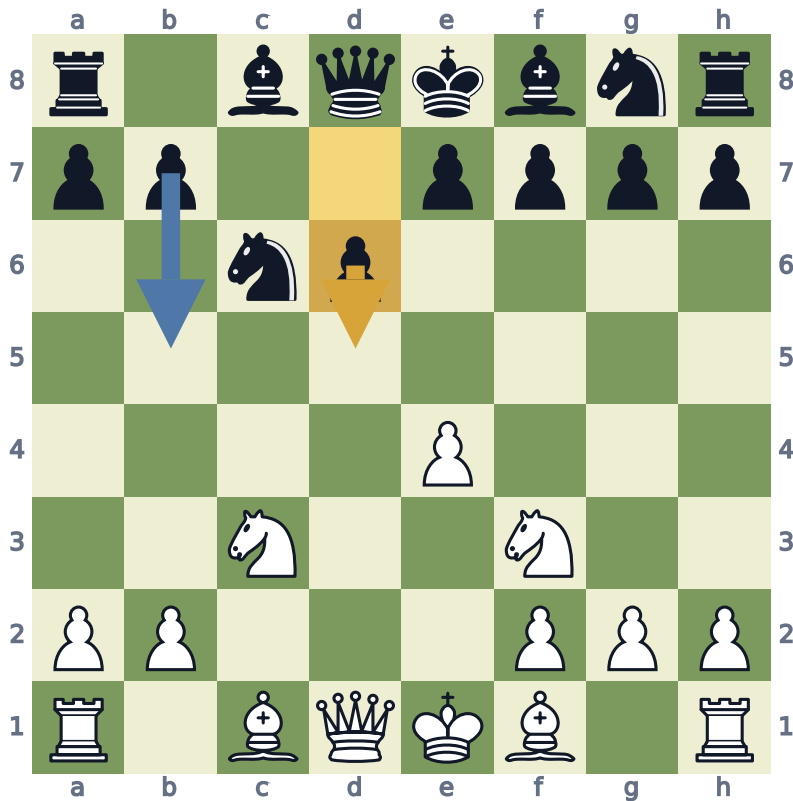
LESSON 084 | PAGE 24

Play: Declining into an Alapin*Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will respect White's initiative without becoming frightened by it, using concrete development and central control.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Accepting the gambit



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black takes a pawn but gives White open lines and rapid development. Survival depends on development, not on defending the extra pawn at all costs.

DECISION RULE

Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Control d5 and e5, develop every piece, and return the pawn if it neutralizes White's initiative.

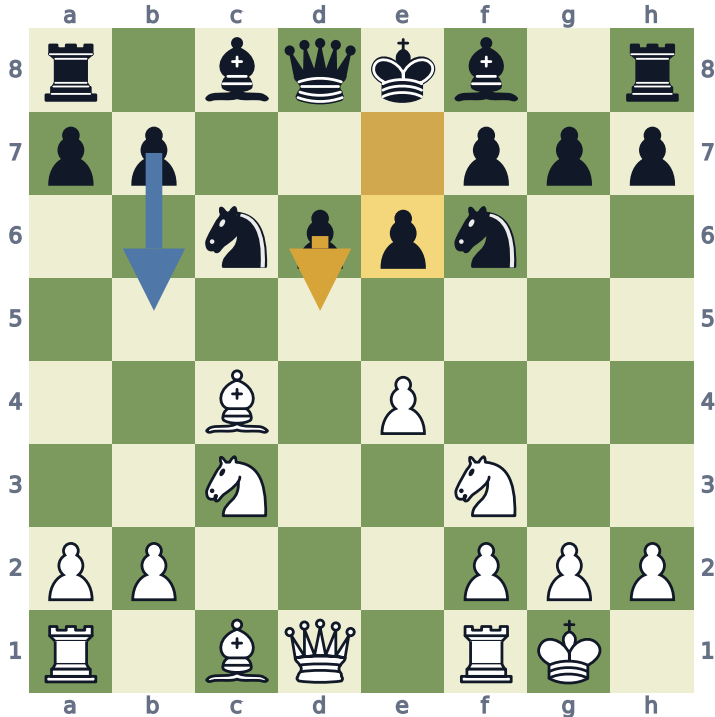
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White places rooks on central files, attacks e6 and f7, and uses sacrifices to keep Black uncastled.

MEMORY RULE | In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black takes a pawn but gives White open lines and rapid development. Survival depends on development, not on defending the extra pawn at all costs.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Control d5 and e5, develop every piece, and return the pawn if it neutralizes White's initiative.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White places rooks on central files, attacks e6 and f7, and uses sacrifices to keep Black uncastled.

FAILURE MODE

Spending tempi to preserve the c3 pawn or another material detail while the king stays central.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

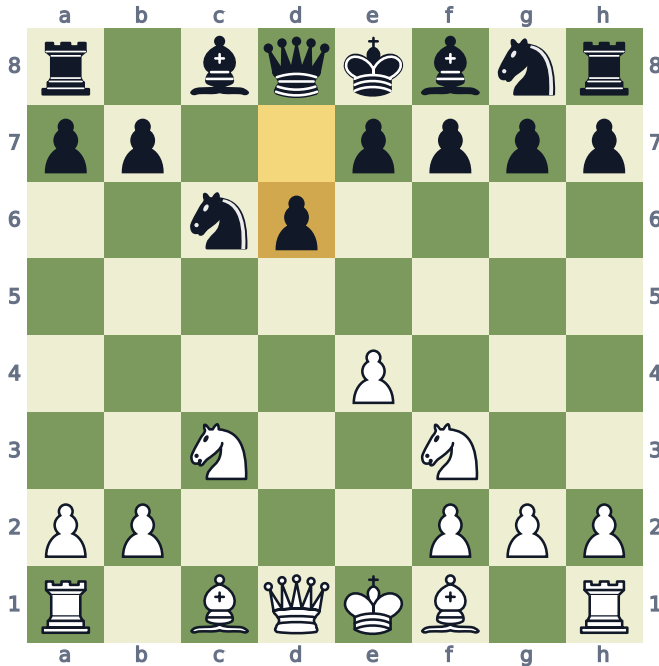
RULE | In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. O-O e6



- c3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- dxc3: Black releases tension by capturing on c3; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nxc3: White releases tension by capturing on c3; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black takes a pawn but gives White open lines and rapid development. Survival depends on development, not on defending the extra pawn at all costs.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat? White's resistance is: White places rooks on central files, attacks e6 and f7, and uses sacrifices to keep Black uncastled. The line fails as a template when: Spending tempi to preserve the c3 pawn or another material detail while the king stays central.

STORE THIS | In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

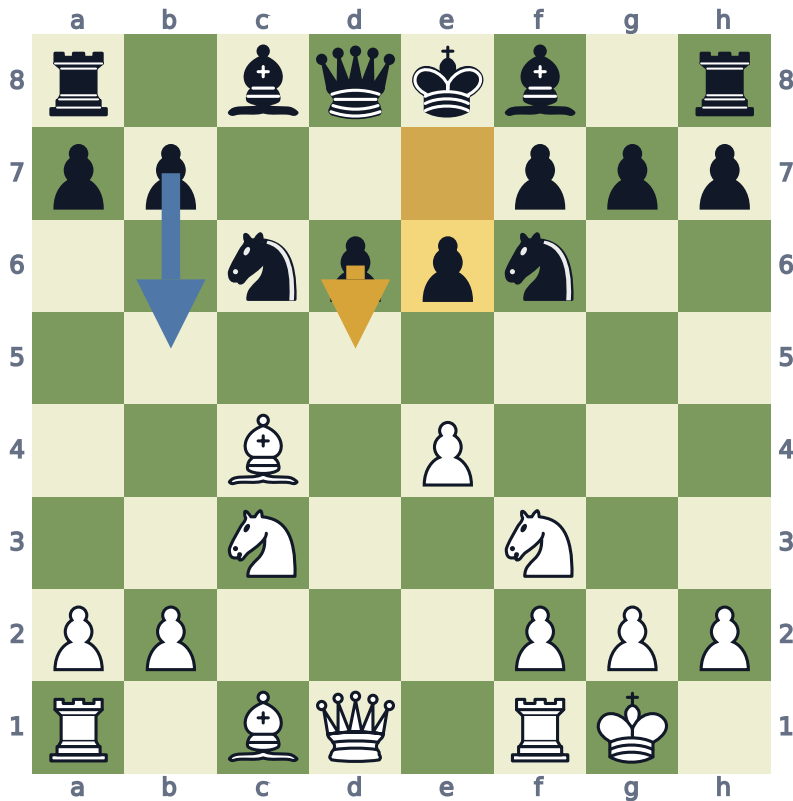
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Accepting the gambit



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black takes a pawn but gives White open lines and rapid development. Survival depends on development, not on defending the extra pawn at all costs.

DECISION RULE

Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Control d5 and e5, develop every piece, and return the pawn if it neutralizes White's initiative.

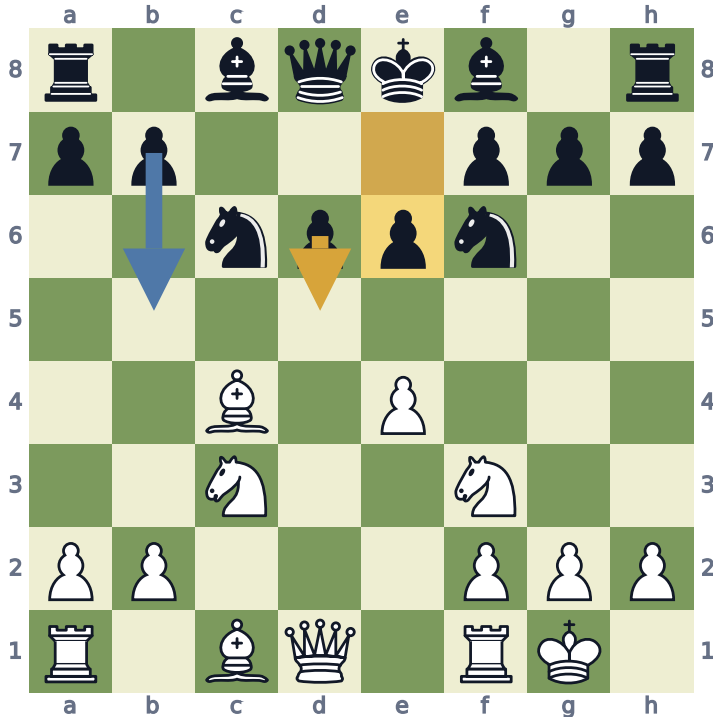
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White places rooks on central files, attacks e6 and f7, and uses sacrifices to keep Black uncastled.

MEMORY RULE | In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black takes a pawn but gives White open lines and rapid development. Survival depends on development, not on defending the extra pawn at all costs.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Control d5 and e5, develop every piece, and return the pawn if it neutralizes White's initiative.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White places rooks on central files, attacks e6 and f7, and uses sacrifices to keep Black uncastled.

FAILURE MODE

Spending tempi to preserve the c3 pawn or another material detail while the king stays central.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

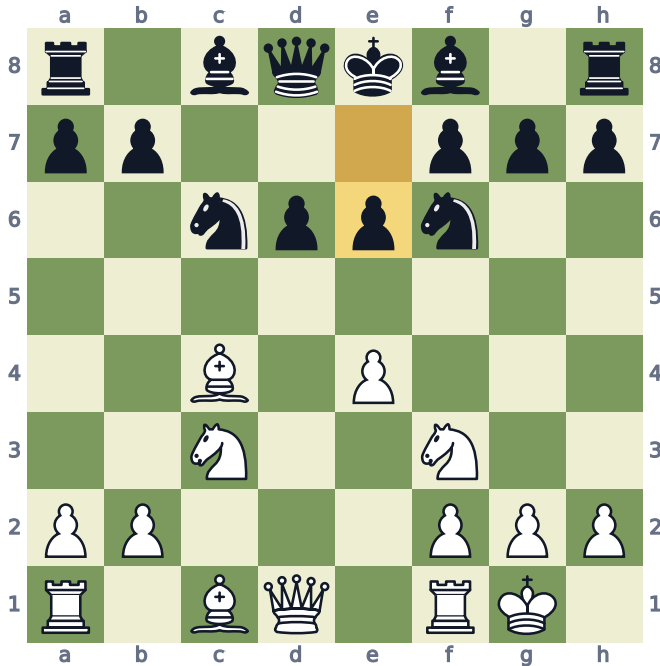
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. O-O e6



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bc4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black takes a pawn but gives White open lines and rapid development. Survival depends on development, not on defending the extra pawn at all costs.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat? White's resistance is: White places rooks on central files, attacks e6 and f7, and uses sacrifices to keep Black uncastled. The line fails as a template when: Spending tempi to preserve the c3 pawn or another material detail while the king stays central.

STORE THIS | In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

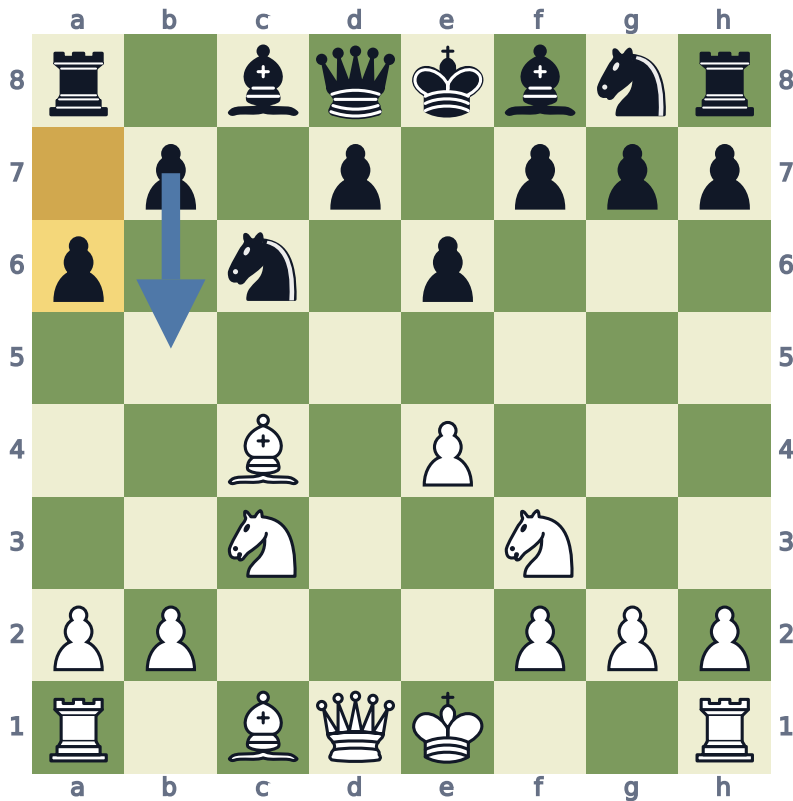
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. O-O e6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The e5-square blockade



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...e6 denies White an easy e5 advance and supports development, but it makes the dark squares and d6 setup important.

DECISION RULE

Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use ...a6 and ...b5 only when they gain a real bishop tempo and do not neglect ...Nf6 and king safety.

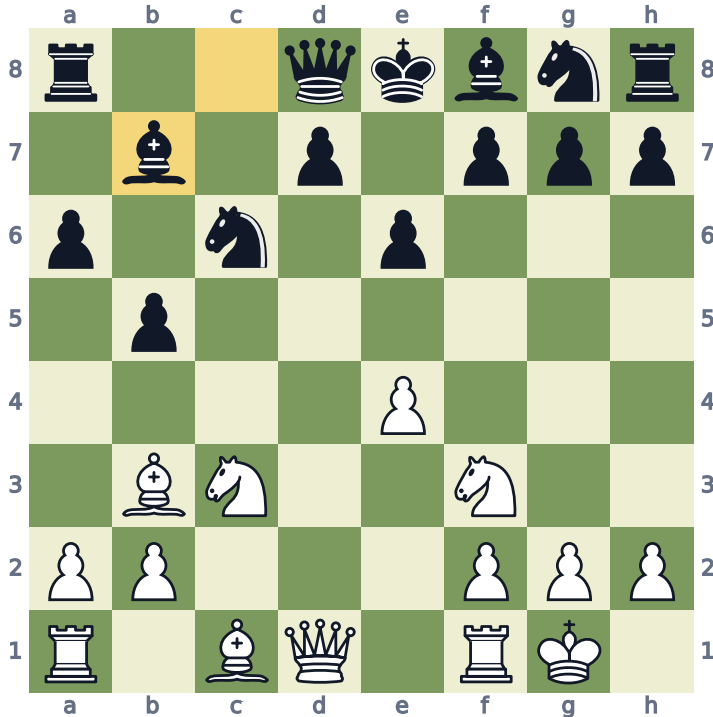
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White exploits the lead in development with e5, Qe2, Rd1, and tactical pressure on the king.

MEMORY RULE | A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...e6 denies White an easy e5 advance and supports development, but it makes the dark squares and d6 setup important.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use ...a6 and ...b5 only when they gain a real bishop tempo and do not neglect ...Nf6 and king safety.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White exploits the lead in development with e5, Qe2, Rd1, and tactical pressure on the king.

FAILURE MODE

Winning tempi on one bishop while three black pieces remain asleep.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

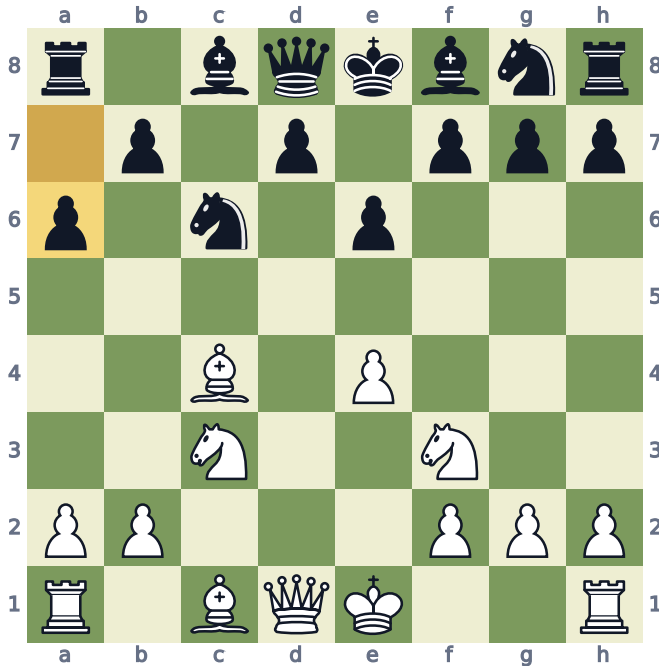
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 e6 6. Bc4 a6 7. O-O b5 8. Bb3 Bb7



- Nxc3: White releases tension by capturing on c3; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bc4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e6 denies White an easy e5 advance and supports development, but it makes the dark squares and d6 setup important.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one? White's resistance is: White exploits the lead in development with e5, Qe2, Rd1, and tactical pressure on the king. The line fails as a template when: Winning tempi on one bishop while three black pieces remain asleep.

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1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

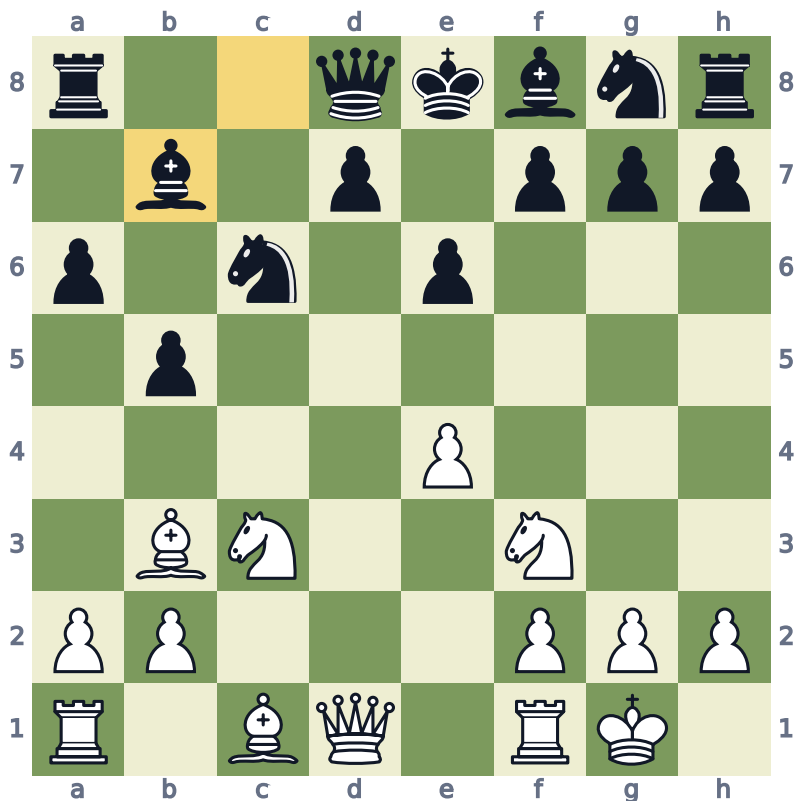
1. ...e6 denies White an easy e5 advance and supports development, but it makes the dark squares and d6 setup important. 2. Use ...a6 and ...b5 only when they gain a real bishop tempo and do not neglect ...Nf6 and king safety. 3. White exploits the lead in development with e5, Qe2, Rd1, and tactical pressure on the king. 4. Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one? 5. Winning tempi on one bishop while three black pieces remain asleep.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 e6 6. Bc4 a6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The e5-square blockade



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...e6 denies White an easy e5 advance and supports development, but it makes the dark squares and d6 setup important.

DECISION RULE

Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use ...a6 and ...b5 only when they gain a real bishop tempo and do not neglect ...Nf6 and king safety.

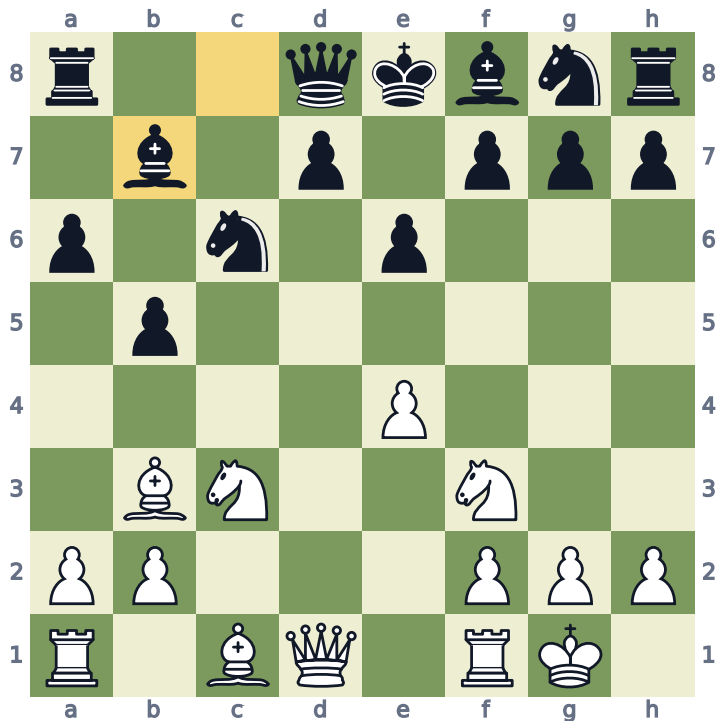
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White exploits the lead in development with e5, Qe2, Rd1, and tactical pressure on the king.

MEMORY RULE | A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...e6 denies White an easy e5 advance and supports development, but it makes the dark squares and d6 setup important.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use ...a6 and ...b5 only when they gain a real bishop tempo and do not neglect ...Nf6 and king safety.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White exploits the lead in development with e5, Qe2, Rd1, and tactical pressure on the king.

FAILURE MODE

Winning tempi on one bishop while three black pieces remain asleep.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

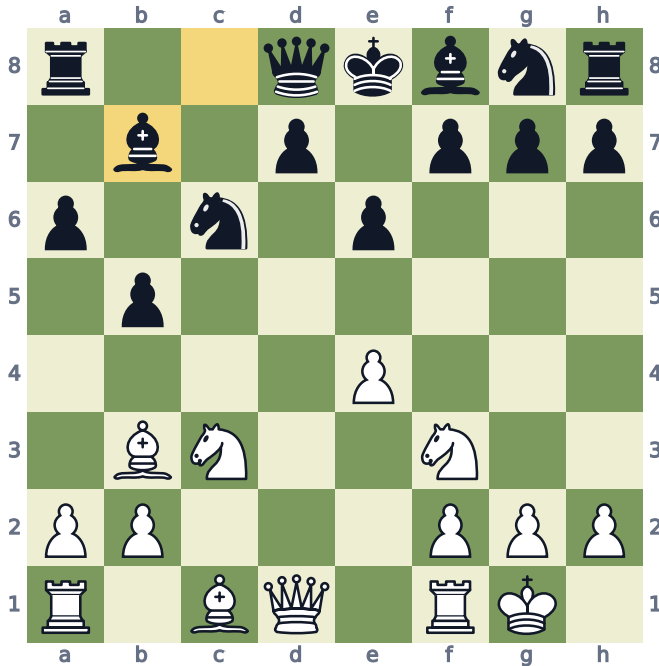
RULE | A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 e6 6. Bc4 a6 7. O-O b5 8. Bb3 Bb7



- Bc4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- b5: Black starts queenside expansion and prepares files or a bishop diagonal.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e6 denies White an easy e5 advance and supports development, but it makes the dark squares and d6 setup important.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one? White's resistance is: White exploits the lead in development with e5, Qe2, Rd1, and tactical pressure on the king. The line fails as a template when: Winning tempi on one bishop while three black pieces remain asleep.

STORE THIS | A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

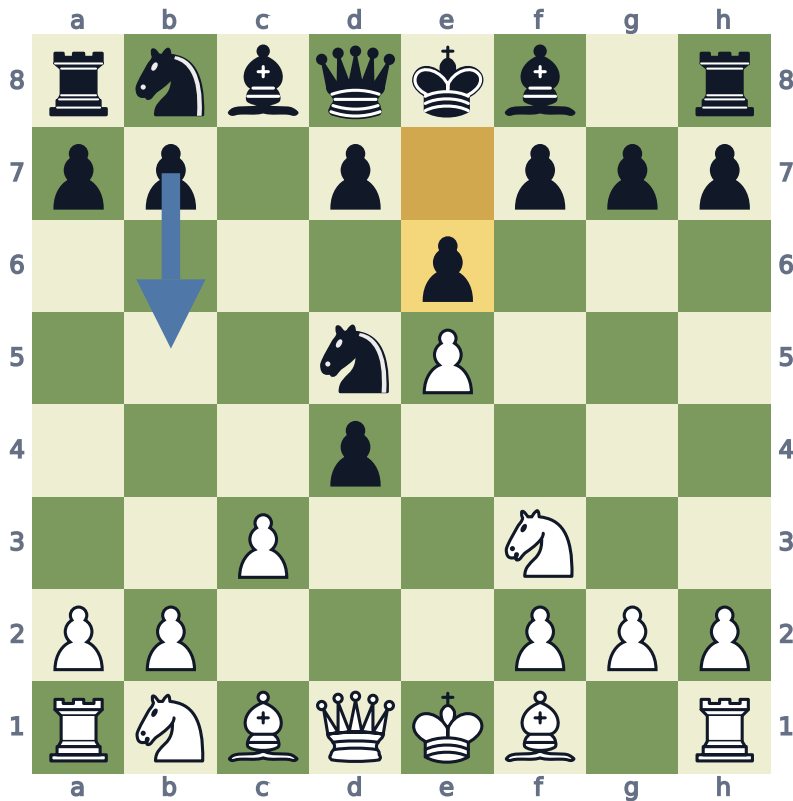
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Bc4 a6 7. O-O b5 8. Bb3 Bb7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Declining into an Alapin



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Declining with ...Nf6 avoids the gambit pawn and transposes to an Alapin-type center where e5 and d4 are the targets.

DECISION RULE

Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Attack the advanced center, develop with tempo, and know that declining changes the problem rather than removing theory.

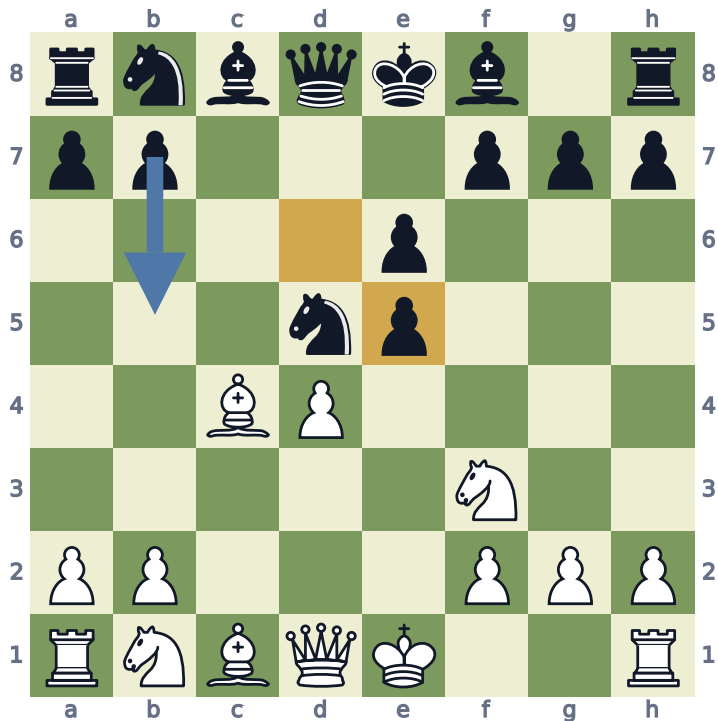
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White keeps space and uses quick development to support the center.

MEMORY RULE | Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Declining with ...Nf6 avoids the gambit pawn and transposes to an Alapin-type center where e5 and d4 are the targets.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Attack the advanced center, develop with tempo, and know that declining changes the problem rather than removing theory.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White keeps space and uses quick development to support the center.

FAILURE MODE

Calling the gambit declined and then playing passively against the broad center.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

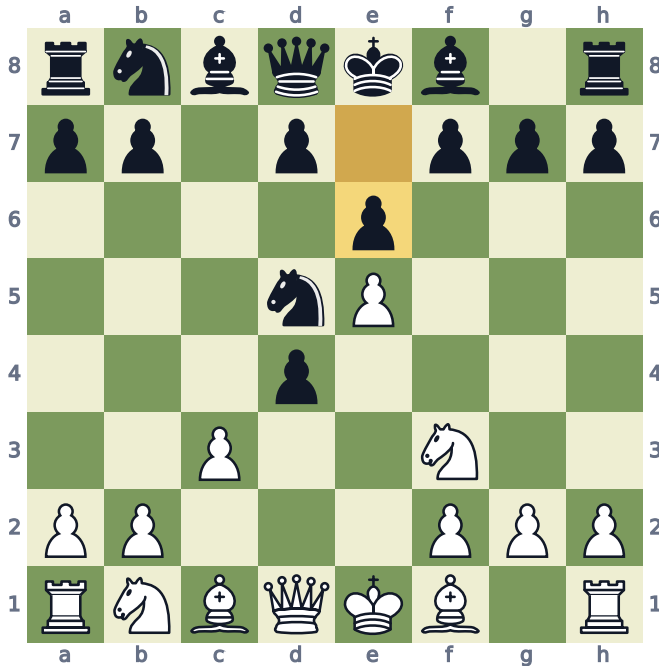
RULE | Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 Nf6 4. e5 Nd5 5. Nf3 e6 6. cxd4 d6 7. Bc4 dxe5



- c3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- e5: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nd5: Black reroutes a knight to d5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
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- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Declining with ...Nf6 avoids the gambit pawn and transposes to an Alapin-type center where e5 and d4 are the targets.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight? White's resistance is: White keeps space and uses quick development to support the center. The line fails as a template when: Calling the gambit declined and then playing passively against the broad center.

STORE THIS | Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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ANSWER KEY

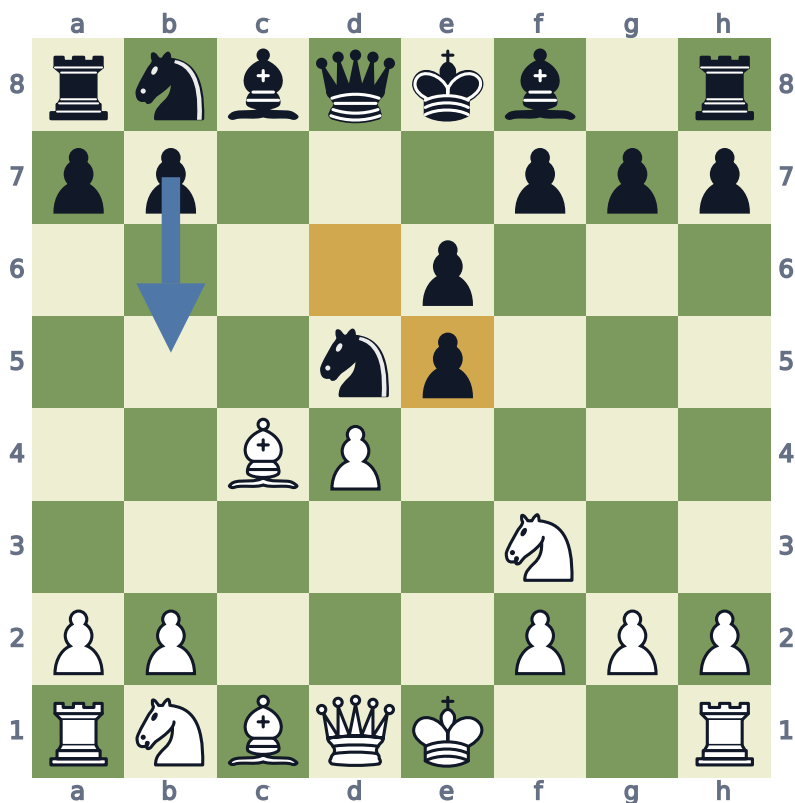
1. Declining with ...Nf6 avoids the gambit pawn and transposes to an Alapin-type center where e5 and d4 are the targets. 2. Attack the advanced center, develop with tempo, and know that declining changes the problem rather than removing theory. 3. White keeps space and uses quick development to support the center. 4. Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight? 5. Calling the gambit declined and then playing passively against the broad center.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. c3 Nf6 4. e5 Nd5 5. Nf3 e6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Declining into an Alapin



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Declining with ...Nf6 avoids the gambit pawn and transposes to an Alapin-type center where e5 and d4 are the targets.

DECISION RULE

Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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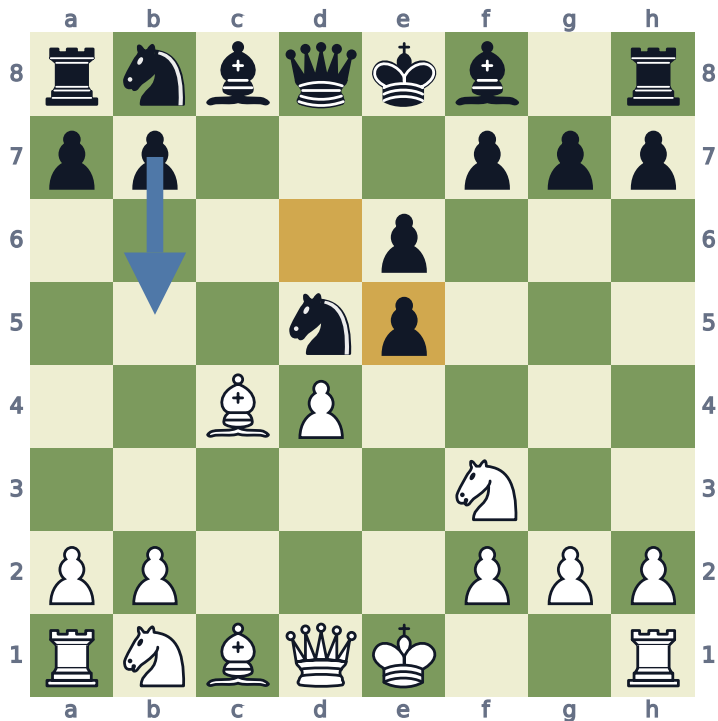
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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FAILURE MODE

Calling the gambit declined and then playing passively against the broad center.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

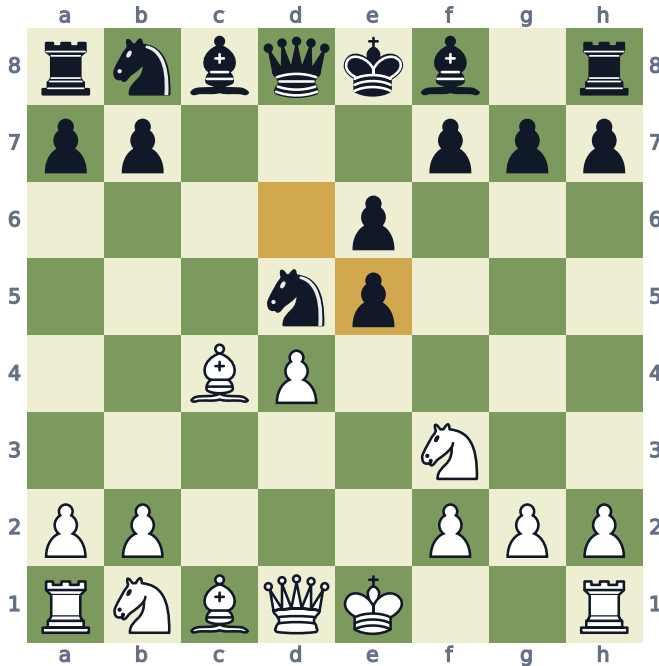
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 Nf6 4. e5 Nd5 5. Nf3 e6 6. cxd4 d6 7. Bc4 dxe5



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- cxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bc4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- dxe5: Black releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Declining with ...Nf6 avoids the gambit pawn and transposes to an Alapin-type center where e5 and d4 are the targets.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight? White's resistance is: White keeps space and uses quick development to support the center. The line fails as a template when: Calling the gambit declined and then playing passively against the broad center.

STORE THIS | Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Declining with ...Nf6 avoids the gambit pawn and transposes to an Alapin-type center where e5 and d4 are the targets. 2. Attack the advanced center, develop with tempo, and know that declining changes the problem rather than removing theory. 3. White keeps space and uses quick development to support the center. 4. Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight? 5. Calling the gambit declined and then playing passively against the broad center.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nf3 e6 6. cxd4 d6 7. Bc4 dxe5

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 079 Decode: Accepting the gambit

Prompt: Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat?

Recall: In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

LESSON 080 Play: Accepting the gambit

Prompt: Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat?

Recall: In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

LESSON 081 Decode: The e5-square blockade

Prompt: Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one?

Recall: A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.

LESSON 082 Play: The e5-square blockade

Prompt: Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one?

Recall: A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.

LESSON 083 Decode: Declining into an Alapin

Prompt: Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight?

Recall: Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.

LESSON 084 Play: Declining into an Alapin

Prompt: Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight?

Recall: Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Accepting the gambit

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. O-O e6

Decision: Which move develops with defense against White's next forcing threat?

Memory: In a gambit, extra material is stored value; spend it to finish development.

CARD 2

The e5-square blockade

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 e6 6. Bc4 a6 7. O-O b5 8. Bb3 Bb7

Decision: Does the queenside expansion solve a development problem or create one?

Memory: A pawn gain survives only behind a completed development shell.

CARD 3

Declining into an Alapin

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 Nf6 4. e5 Nd5 5. Nf3 e6 6. cxd4 d6 7. Bc4 dxe5

Decision: Can Black undermine e5 or d4 without allowing a tactical jump on the centralized knight?

Memory: Declining a gambit means choosing a center you understand, not refusing to fight.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
079 Decode: Accepting the gambit	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
080 Play: Accepting the gambit	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
081 Decode: The e5-square blockade	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
082 Play: The e5-square blockade	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
083 Decode: Declining into an Alapin	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
084 Play: Declining into an Alapin	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.